

Does the claim that God exists outside of time give us
reason to reject premise (2) of the foreknowledge
argument?

It does look like, if Aquinas' view is right, (2) is false. That
is good for the defender of free will.

We'll shortly consider some ways of responding to Edwards' argument. But first let's think about how Edwards' argument might be related to an argument for fatalism.

Suppose that someone did not believe in God — and hence rejected premise (2) of Edwards' argument — but did believe that there were truths about all of our future actions. Could they give an argument similar to Edwards' argument?

There are truths
about our future
actions.

In the past, God
had
foreknowledge of
our future
actions.

To get a grip on this, imagine that one learned of another universe, which had its own system of time and space. And suppose one was given all of the information about everything that ever happens in that universe, and the time at which it happens. So, in particular, you know everything about every free action in that universe. But it's not like you knew of every action **before** that action occurred — you don't exist in the time of that universe.

Let's look again at the premises which make
reference to time.

1. We have no choice about past facts.
2. In the past, God had foreknowledge of our future actions.
3. We have no choice about the fact that God knows that in the future I will perform a certain action. (1,2)

We started off with two arguments for the reality of fate.

The first was the Logical Argument for Fate, which was based on the Law of the Excluded Middle.

The law of the excluded middle

For any proposition P , either P is true or $\text{Not-}P$ is true.

But what if we denied this? Perhaps claims about future free actions — like claims about what you will eat for dinner tonight — are neither true nor false, but simply “undetermined.” They do not now have any truth-value (though they will later).

There are two central objections to open theism.

The second central objection to open theism is more theological than philosophical. And this is just that it is hard to square the view that God does not know what we are going to do with certain features of the main monotheistic religions.

Various passages in both the Old and New Testaments (as well as in the Koran) seem to imply the existence of divine foreknowledge.

Consider, for example the following well-known passage from the Gospel of Matthew, in which Jesus is speaking to Peter:

“Truly, I tell you, this very night,
before the rooster crows, you will
deny me three times.”

One who denies divine foreknowledge seems forced into saying either that Jesus did not really know what he said to be true, or that Peter's denial was not free.

Perhaps there's a way out. One might say that Peter's decision was free, but that the relevant choice had already been freely made prior to Jesus's saying this — so that the choice was free despite the action being determined at the time of Jesus's statement.

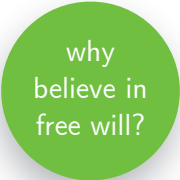
We have no
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past.



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
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three
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3. We have not checked that

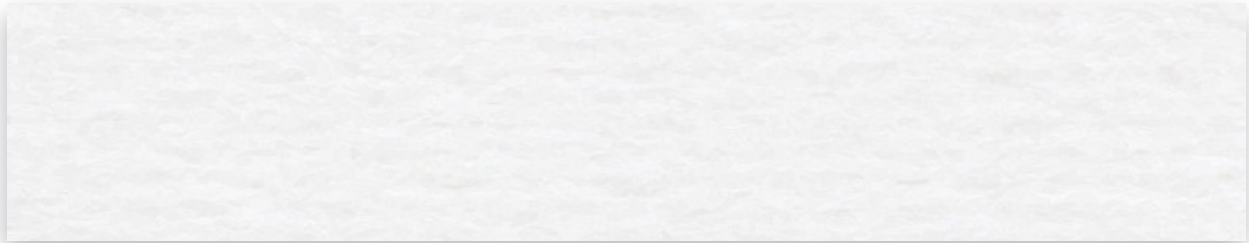
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So now consider a possible scenario in which someone exactly like you would get

a Predictor. By the above line of thought, this person would lack free will. But

never had any. So they lacked free will before getting a Predict.

that Predict did not **take away** their free will; it just shows them that they

either.

But this person was stipulated to be exactly like you. So you don't have free will,

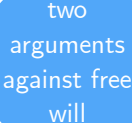
So far we've looked at two imaginary thought experiments—the story of Osmo,

and the example of the Predictor — which seem to show that if there is such a

things as fate, then there is no free will.

serious challenge to the reality of free will?

Our question is: do either fatigue or foreknowledge pose a



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
free will?



three
ways out

Our first topic today is the oldest challenge to the existence of free will: the challenge to

freedom that comes from fate.

(5) Let's look at what happens if we

with reference to the being of truth about

replace reference to God's foreknowledge

our future actions.

God only shows up in premises (2) and



all of our activities.

God knows that in the future I will

perform a certain action (1,2)

1. We have no direct facts.

3 We have not at the fact that

2* In the past, there were truths about

(3, 4, 5)



that if it is true that I will perform

5* We have not noticed the fact

acaioid.

then we have the choice about q.

0 We have achieved what we

4. If we have no choice about p , and no

choice about the fact that if p , then q ,

will perform various actions.

some action, then I will prefer that

The fatalist argument

There are truths
about our future
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In the past, God
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We have no
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past.

Let's turn to our last line of response to the two arguments. This is

no choice about the past.

to deny the assumption, common to both arguments, that we have

There are truths
about our future
actions.

We have no
choice about the
past.